usual *vakil* with little scruples but a change soon overtook him and he began to confront the corrupt local police. In the ensuing tussle, the police foisted a case on him, but VOC worsted them and ensured that a head constable was dismissed. Coloured by this experience, VOC held a dim view of police and lawyers—a view that only hardened after his incarceration and being a lifelong political suspect.

Soon it was clear that Ottapidaram was too small for a man of his abilities, and in 1900—a move that coincided with the death of Valliammai and remarriage to Meenakshi—VOC moved to Tuticorin. Tuticorin at that time had one of the two sub-courts in the district; it also had a district munsiff's court and a bench of the sub-magistrate. Tirunelveli was notorious as 'the most litigious of the districts', accounting for 6 per cent of all suits filed in the sprawling Madras Presidency.[11] No wonder, VOC built a flourishing practice. At the time of his plunge into full-time political work, he was known to make as much as Rs 500 a month. Stationed in a vibrant port town, he was soon drawn into public life. In addition to his intellectual interests, he began to read extensively on Tamil literature and religion. Apart from being involved in the local Saiva Sabha he also edited a literary monthly, *Vivekabhanu*. Avidly following the happenings around the world, VOC was introduced to the political ideas of 'Lokmanya' Bal Gangadhar Tilak, the radical leader of the Congress from Maharashtra, as early as in 1893. His name also figures in an early police intelligence report on a preparatory meeting for the 1898 Madras session of the Congress. With the partition of Bengal, VOC was sucked into the vortex of the Swadeshi movement. In 1905, a thirty-three-year-old VOC was in his prime. With wide experience, a successful practice and considerable learning, he was ready for greater things. But none would have dreamed of what he would achieve in the succeeding years.

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VOC's statement in court in the sedition case he later faced briefly outlines how he came to be engaged in the Swadeshi shipping enterprise: